The US and China's AI Action Plans are now published. What should OSPO leaders do next?

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The release of the **US 2025 America's AI Action Plan** and **China's 13-point Action Plan on Global AI Governance** marks a pivotal moment. These plans outline how nations govern AI and have implications on how organizations should navigate AI and open source AI development across increasingly divergent jurisdictions. If you haven't read these two plans yet, here's a quick reference to previous posts I've published early this week:

- A deep dive into the U.S. 2025 AI Action Plan
- A breakdown of China's 13-point Global AI Governance Plan

It will take weeks, if not months, before we see any operational execution from these plans. That delay creates a valuable window for Open Source Program Offices (OSPOs) to regroup, rethink strategy, and prepare for what's coming. I've written previously about the expanding scope of OSPOs, especially in the context of AI (What OSPOs Must Now Do Differently).

These new AI action plans from global superpowers add another layer of complexity and urgency. Based on my experience founding and leading OSPOs across multiple international organizations, here's what I would prioritize if I were in an OSPO leadership role today.

[1] Shift from "Open Source Enablement" to "Policy Translation"

The OSPO mission has historically been centered on enabling the use of open source, contributing to projects and initiatives, and community engagement. That historical scope is no longer sufficient in the context of AI. OSPOs now need to shift some of their focus to:

- Translate national AI principles like “human-centric AI” or “safe and controllable systems” into internal development practices. For example, what is “safe and controllable” and how does that translate in practice, how does that relate to some of the AI frameworks used today, and what correction action should we take to be aligned with these national principles?
- Bridge policy and engineering by working with legal and compliance teams to map international AI policies to technical and process guidelines. That process includes identifying specific actions, establishing checklists, and assigning owners
- Guide AI product teams on model and dataset alignment with jurisdictional rules (China’s traceability mandates, US NIST-aligned assurance frameworks)

This effort focuses on building workflows and setting technical expectations that bring policy into engineering reality.

[2] Treat Foundation Membership as Geopolitical Positioning

Foundation engagement may no longer be geopolitically neutral. China’s AI Action Plan calls for new multilateral institutions potentially competitive with US-backed ecosystems. That call may be putting foundation affiliations under a different kind of scrutiny, where membership in foundations, especially foundations focused on AI and AI ecosystem coordination, could signal implicit alignment. OSPOs need to:

- Audit current memberships. Who governs these foundations? What jurisdictions dominate board representation and agenda-setting?
- Understand exposure: Are you over-indexed on foundations that might soon carry geopolitical baggage?
- Be proactive: Prepare talking points, internal FAQs, and response plans if questions arise about perceived alignment

This effort doesn’t imply the need to sever ties with any foundation as much as it requires recognizing that geopolitical signalling is now part of the landscape.

[3] Operationalize Attribution, Traceability, and Provenance

Both AI Action Plans emphasize auditability, but China’s plan goes further and explicitly calls for “controllable” and “traceable” AI (what that means in practice is to be seen). In contrast, the US plan builds on NIST’s AI Risk Management Framework. Both action plans imply new expectations, and that emphasis has significant implications for open source AI workflows:

- Training data lineage: Can you trace how your model was trained and on what datasets?
- Component provenance: Can you track model weights, fine-tunes, and reused modules to their origin?

- AI-generated code attribution: Do you have policies for managing and documenting AI-generated pull requests?

As OSPO leaders, you'll need to:

- Establish internal documentation policies for model inputs, outputs, and usage
- Integrate metadata standards for AI contributions and dependencies
- Work with DevRel, Legal, and Engineering to ensure accountability practices are in place

[4] Monitor and Manage Regulatory Forks

With divergent national strategies, we're entering a world where open source AI models and tools *may* fork (to be seen) for regulatory reasons if they want to exist in both jurisdictions and meet divergent compliance requirements. This will require OSPOs to:

- Track "regulatory forks" of OSS projects that evolve under different compliance regimes (one for Chinese markets, one for global)
- Help engineering and product teams understand when such forks are necessary or when a unified project can meet cross-border requirements
- Develop policies around what type of fork your company will contribute to, deploy, or sponsor
- Create a strategy: Which forks will your org support? Which will you avoid?

[5] Participate in AI Governance Standards Bodies

Both AI Action Plans call out the role of standardization bodies: ISO, IEC, ITU, and regional equivalents in shaping AI governance. OSPOs should now be front and center any standards work/planning, and OSPO leaders should:

- Identify the AI-relevant standards bodies that their company engages with
- Embed an OSPO representative into those efforts, or coordinate with legal/policy leads to ensure open source implications are understood
- Advocate for OSS-aligned standards, open documentation, reference implementations, reproducibility, as defaults

[6] Update Contribution Due Diligence

The geopolitical layer now matters, and it affects the contributions to or from entities in high-risk jurisdictions (however defined by your organization), which will increasingly require additional due diligence. OSPOs should anticipate export controls, data residency rules, and origin-based restrictions to bleed into open source practices. What should OSPOs do?

- Audit key dependencies and understand where critical libraries and models originate
- Update contribution workflows to include geopolitical vetting for contributions to AI models or libraries with security, privacy, or geopolitical implications
- Collaborate cross-functionally with compliance, software supply chain, and security teams to future-proof contribution workflow and associated tooling

[7] Evolve the OSPO Mandate

All the changes discussed in the previous sections mean the OSPO is no longer a back-office compliance/consumption/contribution function. OSPOs are evolving to strategic intelligence hubs and becoming a forward-looking bridge between engineering, legal, policy, and product strategy.

OSPOs now need:

- Staff who can read AI legislation and translate it into actionable engineering guidance
- A seat at the table when your company sets AI product strategy or engages in global AI / open source standards
- New workflows or ways to track how models are built, reused, licensed, and governed

"It's Complicated"

The AI policy landscape is now the new operating environment. The world's largest economies have made their AI governance intentions clear, and open source is caught in the middle. OSPOs that treat this new environment as business as usual will find themselves out of sync with regulatory expectations and strategic priorities and risk being locked out of the frameworks shaping global AI infrastructure. If OSPOs engage early, they will be able to ensure open source AI remains both viable and valuable in a fragmented world.

The path forward is complicated. OSPOs that step up will no doubt play a central role in navigating the next era of AI.

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If you're interested in OSPO-related topics, I have developed this series: https://www.linkedin.com/feed/update/urn:li:activity:7335681682164830208/

Thanks for reading. Please feel free to share this post with your network if you find it helpful.

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About the Author

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